

MIG-16

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-16

Age: 47

Gender: Male

Country of origin: Mexico

Host country: United States

Years in host country: 15

Occupation: Agricultural Worker

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I came to the United States fifteen years ago to work in agriculture and to support my family back in Mexico, because the economic hardship in my rural village left almost no options for a man who wanted to provide for his children. The wages here, though modest by American standards, were far better than anything I could earn at home, enough to actually make a difference to my family's lives. I crossed the border to give my children the opportunities that I myself never had, sacrificing years of being away from home, away from my wife and kids and my community, in order to do so. It was not a decision made lightly, but it was the only path I could see toward giving my family a genuine future, and I have held onto that purpose through everything.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means being recognised for the essential work I do feeding this country, rather than being treated as invisible when it is convenient and as a criminal when it is not. It shows itself when my labour is genuinely respected and my humanity is acknowledged, when I am seen as a person and a worker rather than as a problem or a threat. Belonging, for me, would be having a real path to legal status after so many years of honest contribution, of picking the food that ends up on American tables, being seen at last as a genuine member of this community that I have served faithfully for a decade and a half, rather than living forever in the shadows as I have had to.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: Yes, I have faced significant and painful xenophobia, especially given the political climate of recent years, which has so often demonised Mexican immigrants specifically and cast us as villains. I have been called ugly slurs and treated as a criminal despite having worked honestly and hard for fifteen years without ever causing anyone harm. The rhetoric that labels people like us as invaders, as threats, as somehow less than human, is deeply and personally hurtful when the reality is that I have given my labour, my strength, and years of my life to this country's agriculture, asking for very little in return and receiving, too often, only suspicion and contempt from those who benefit from my work.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The greatest challenges have been living all these years without legal status, in constant, grinding fear of deportation and of being suddenly separated from my family, a fear that never entirely leaves you and shapes every decision. The work itself is physically grueling, long hours of hard labour in harsh conditions, extreme heat and cold, for low pay and few protections. The language barrier and my undocumented status together have kept me perpetually vulnerable to exploitation by employers who know I cannot easily complain, and unable to fully participate in the society around me, to put down roots openly, or to claim the rights and protections that others take for granted. It is a life lived in the margins.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: Among my fellow farmworkers, who are mostly other Mexicans and Central Americans in the same difficult situation, there is a strong and genuine solidarity born of shared struggle and shared understanding, and that fellowship has meant a great deal to me over the years. Some employers treat us fairly and with a measure of respect, while others exploit our vulnerable status ruthlessly, paying less than promised or ignoring dangerous conditions. The camaraderie among the workers, who all understand the hardships and the fears intimately because we all live them, helps us endure. We look out for one another as best we can within a system that too often does not protect us or even acknowledge us.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I hold my Mexican identity strongly and proudly through my language, my food, my music, my Catholic faith, and my deep and abiding connection to my hometown and to the family I left behind there, whom I think about every single day. I have adapted to life in the United States out of sheer necessity, learning what I needed to survive and work here, but I remain deeply rooted in my own culture, which is the core of who I am. After fifteen years I live, in a real sense, between two countries, my body and my labour here in America but my heart still very much in Mexico, always.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: American media and political rhetoric too often criminalise Mexican immigrants, portraying us as threats, as burdens, as invaders, rather than as the workers who quietly sustain the entire food supply that the country depends on. This kind of coverage fuels hostility toward us and strips away our humanity in the public eye. Rarely is the actual reality shown: that we do backbreaking, essential work that most others simply will not do, in the fields and orchards, contributing enormously to the economy while asking for very little and receiving even less recognition. The gap between what we contribute and how we are portrayed is vast and, to me, deeply unjust.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: As an undocumented worker, I have had almost no access to integration support or official services throughout my time here, living quite literally in the shadows for fifteen long years, unable to step forward and claim help without risking everything. Some community and church organisations have offered assistance and a measure of dignity along the way, and I am genuinely grateful for their compassion and their willingness to see us as human beings. But the complete absence of any real

pathway to legalisation has kept me, and millions of others in the same position, perpetually marginalised and vulnerable despite our years of contribution, unable ever to fully belong or to build our lives out in the open like everyone else.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: My children, some of whom were born here in the United States, are American citizens, and that fact is my greatest pride and the entire reason for all my sacrifice and all my years of absence and hard labour. They speak English fluently and have access to opportunities that I could never even have dreamed of at their age, real chances for education and advancement. I have missed a great deal of their childhood while working far away to provide for them, moments I can never get back, but seeing them educated, safe, and full of possibility makes every hardship and every sacrifice worthwhile in the end. They are the future I crossed the border to give them.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, Americans genuinely need to recognise just how dependent their food system is on immigrant labour like mine, how the fruit and vegetables on their tables reach them through the hands of workers like me. Humane immigration reform, offering a real path to legalisation for those who have worked and contributed for years, is essential and long overdue. The media must show our humanity and our contributions honestly rather than caricaturing us as threats. And personal contact helps, as it always does; when people actually meet the workers behind their food and come to know us as human beings with families and hopes, the harmful stereotypes often begin to break down and give way to understanding.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope, more than almost anything, for immigration reform that would finally grant me legal status after fifteen years of honest work, so that I could at last live without the constant fear of deportation and could visit my family in Mexico, whom I have not been able to see freely for so long. I dream of my children succeeding in careers and lives that were impossible for me, fulfilling the promise that my sacrifice was meant to buy them. And I hope, in time, to be able to retire with some measure of dignity, knowing that I secured a genuinely better future for my family through all my years of labour.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to newcomers is to work honestly and to build a solid reputation, because your good name is one of the few things entirely within your control, but also to know your rights even without documents, because you have more of them than you might think and knowledge is protection. Connect with community and church organisations for support, guidance, and a measure of safety, because they can help in ways you cannot manage alone. Keep your family and your cultural roots close, because they are the source of your strength through the hardest times. And hold onto hope for reform, enduring the difficulties with dignity and patience, because things can change.